

Die Schriften des Neuen Testaments (4 vols.; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck und Ruprecht, 1911-1913), he could not have done so, at least not honestly. But was he honest? At least with reference to John 7:53 - 8:11 (the *P.A.*), I think not. He claimed to have collated some 900 MSS for that pericope, and on that basis posited seven families, or lines of transmission, and even reproduced an alleged archetypal form for each one. Hodges and Farstad took his word for it and reflected his statement of the evidence in their critical apparatus; and I reflect the H-F apparatus in mine (for that pericope) for lack of anything better (except that I guarantee the witness of **M**⁷ [my Family 35], based on my personal examination of Robinson's collations; see below). However, some years ago now, Maurice Robinson did a complete collation of 1,389 MSS that contain the *P.A.*,¹ and I had William Pierpont's photocopy of those collations in my possession for two months, spending most of that time studying those collations. As I did so, it became obvious to me that von Soden 'regularized' the data, arbitrarily 'creating' the alleged archetypal form for his first four families, **M**^{1,2,3,4}—if they exist at all, they are rather fluid. His **M**^{5&6} do exist, having distinct profiles, but they are a bit 'squishy', with enough internal confusion to make the choice of the archetypal form to be arbitrary. In contrast to the above, his **M**⁷ (that I call Family 35) has a solid, unambiguous profile—the archetypal form is demonstrable, empirically determined.

Once upon a time I was led to believe that von Soden's work was reasonably reliable. This was important because his work is basic to both the Hodges-Farstad and Robinson-Pierpont editions of the Majority Text. However, the *Text und Textwert* (*TuT*)² collations demonstrate objectively that not infrequently von Soden is seriously off the mark. With reference to von Soden's treatment of codex 223 K.W. Clark wrote, "Furthermore, our collation has revealed sixty-two errors in 229 readings treated by von Soden".³ 27% in error (62 ÷ 229) is altogether too much, and what is true of MS 223 may be true of other MSS as well. Please stop and think about that for a minute. 27% in error cannot be attributed to mere carelessness,

¹ 240 MSS omit the *PA*, 64 of which are based on Theophylact's commentary. Fourteen others have lacunae, but are not witnesses for total omission. A few others certainly contain the passage but the microfilm is illegible. So, 1389 + 240 + 14 + 7(?) = about 1650 MSS checked by Robinson. That does not include Lectionaries, of which he also checked a fair number. (These are microfilms held by the *Institut* in Münster. We now know that there are many more extant MSS, and probably even more that are not yet 'extant'.) Unfortunately, so far as I know, Robinson has yet to publish his collations, thus making them available to the public at large.

² *Text und Textwert der Griechischen Handschriften des Neuen Testaments* (Ed. Kurt Aland, Berlin: Walter de Gruyter).

³ *Eight American Praxapostoloi* (Kenneth W. Clark, Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1941), p. 12.